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Volume XXXV Number 14; For the week
March 30-April 5, 2010, released on March 29

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• Subscriptions: For assistance contact Customer Care India Today Group, A-61, Sector-57, Noida (UP)-201301. Phones: Toll-free number: 1800 1800 100 (from BSNL/MTNL lines); (05120) 2479900 from Delhi and Faridabad; (0120) 2479900 from Rest of India (Monday-Friday, 10 a.m. - 6 p.m.); Fax: (0120) 4070800; e-mail: avc@indiatoday.com; Mumbai: 022-2444423-6; Fax: 24444358 • Sales: Direct all trade enquiries to General Manager (Sales), Living Media India Limited, 201 Competent House, F-14, Middle Circle, Connaught Place, New Delhi • Regd. Office: K-9 Connaught Circus, New Delhi 110001 • Impact Offices: Trade Centre, 2nd Floor, Kamala City, Senapati Bapat Marg, Lower Parel, Mumbai 400013; Phone: 24983355; Fax: 24982266 • Hamilton House, 1-A, Connaught Place, New Delhi 110001; Phone: 23352233; Fax: 23327330 • 98-A, Dr. Radhakrishnan Salai, 2nd Floor, Mylapore, Chennai-600 004; Phones: 28478526-41; Telex: 041-6177 Into In; Fax: 28472178; Cable: Livmedia Chennai • 201-204 Richmond Towers, 2nd Floor, 12, Richmond Road, Bangalore-560025; Phones: 22212448, 22213037, 22218343; Fax: 22218335; Cable: Livmedia, Bangalore • 52, Jawaharlal Nehru Road, 4th Floor, Kolkata-700071; Phones: 22825398; Fax: 22827254; Cable: Livmedia Kolkata • 6-3-885/7B, Somajiguda, Hyderabad-500082; Phone: 23401657, 23400479, 23410100, 23402481, 23410982, 23411498; Fax: 23403484 • 39/1945, Karakatti Road, Kochi 682016; Phones: 2377057, 2377058; Fax: 2377059 • 2/C, "Suryarath Bldg", 2nd Floor, Behind White House, Panchwati, Office C.G. Road, Ahmedabad-380006; Phone: 26560393, 26560929; Fax: 26565293 • Copyright Living Media India Ltd. All rights reserved throughout the world. Reproduction in any manner is prohibited. Printed and published by Ashish Bagga on behalf of Living Media India Ltd. Printed at Thomson Press India Ltd., 18-35 Milestone, Delhi Mathura Road, Faridabad-121007, (Haryana); A-9, Industrial Complex, Maraimalai Nagar, district Kanchipuram-603209, (Tamil Nadu); and at Plot No. 5-5A, TTC Industrial Area, Thane, Belapur Road, Airoli, Navi Mumbai-400708, (Maharashtra). Published at K-9, Connaught Circus, New Delhi-110001.
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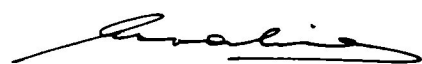
From the editor-in-chief

Last year, when the Indian Premier League (IPL) moved to South Africa, I wrote: "The IPL is nothing short of a Great Gamble. Hopefully, the gamble will pay off and Indian cricket fans will get their money's worth." Less than halfway into the third edition, there's no question that it's paid off, big time. The mix of sports, entertainment and business is a heady combination and Indian fans can't seem to get enough of it. Nor can the sponsors and new franchise owners. Two new teams, Pune and Kochi, were sold last week for a combined \$700 million or about Rs 3,235 crore, more than the Rs 2,853 crore collectively paid by the existing eight franchise owners three years ago. They are only the latest in a long line of businessmen, actors and celebrities who have realised that 45 days of being flashed onscreen nearly as often as the cricketers is enough recompense for the huge sums they are shelling out.

That is all because of one man, the fast talking, indefatigable and dynamic Lalit Modi, the 46-year-old IPL commissioner who came from obscurity five years ago when he joined the Board of Control for Cricket in India (BCCI) from Rajasthan. Surprisingly, for a man who had no real business success to his credit, he converted the IPL into one massive cash cow. He seems to have followed one simple credo: if it moves, monetise it. This year's IPL has come up with ever more creative revenue raising ways. Not only have the team members become walking billboards, he has added Internet rights, theatrical revenue from screenings in bars and multiplexes, after-match parties sponsored by Kingfisher, television shows which stretch the definition of both cricket and entertainment, and ground sponsorship during the strategic time out. Teams are looking at a figure which may just be twice of what they earned from the central pool, which till last year was restricted to broadcasting rights.

The money just keeps pouring in. Ratings are higher this year, allowing Sony to charge Rs 4-5 lakh per 10 second ad, compared to Rs 1.5 lakh for the top soaps. Individual teams have also upped the ante. IPL-1 had 40 brands, Season 2 had 69, while Season 3 already has 80 brands. Teams such as Kolkata Knight Riders which has 12 sponsors and Mumbai Indians as well as Chennai Super Kings which have 10 have made between Rs 40 crore and Rs 50 crore this season, before a single ball was bowled.

Season 3 has also seen the welcome return of crowds to stadiums, with experts estimating a jump of 25 per cent in gate money, which in Season 1 fetched individual teams up to Rs 12 crore each. Then there are the new media rights from innovations such as live streaming on mobile phones, WAP and YouTube. Defenders of the traditional game continue to think of IPL as Evil Incarnate and Modi as its Chief Villain but he is a hugely successful one. The IPL's brand value has more than doubled to \$4.13 billion (over Rs 18,000 crore) since the inaugural season. Our cover story looks at the IPL money machine, whether it can be sustained and what plans Modi has for the future. IPL is now one of the world's most successful brands and the corporate fat cats in the Rs 40,000-box seats can all take some lessons from the carnival that has become cricket's golden goose.


(Aron Purie)



OUR APRIL 2009 COVER